This is a breathtaking vision of the future of the world saturated with the knowledge of God—a world from which the Word cannot be squeezed out, for it has become organically present as the essential structure of one's relationship to the other. This is an enchanting glimpse of the redeemed and healed cosmos. This redemptive transfiguring of finite, cosmic material existence, brought within the infinity of the Spirit's life, is a reversal of the curse. It puts an end to death and suffering and culminates in healing of the relationships between humanity and the rest of creation, as well as between all nonanthropic creatures. There is no more bloodshed and one's existence is not sustained through consuming the other—one's life is no more a function of another's death. This is a restoration of paradise in the generous hospitality of the divine presence.

## Equality, Justice, and Peace

If the human community is created to be the icon of the triune God within the material cosmos, its life is to be marked by consubstantiality, coequality, and perichoresis expressed in loving kenosis and askesis. Without the visible presence of these markers, human communal ontology breaks down and with it the world in and for which it is organically created. The presence of the divine image in each human being regardless of gender, age, race, ethnicity, and religion, becomes the foundation of social equality that finds its expression in comprehensive justice, which, in turn, leads to omnipresent peace manifested as access to life for all. Thus, reflecting on societal justice and planetary flourishing, Jürgen Moltmann suggests that

> the old saying, *Fiat justitia pereat mundi*—'let justice be done though the earth perish'—is assuming deadly righteousness and justice. But if righteousness is supposed to create peace and life, the saying ought to run *Fiat justicia vivat mundi*—'let justice and righteousness be done so that the earth may live'.[125]

Indeed, the realities of equality, justice, and peace cannot be separated from one another. They are organically and functionally correlated as one becomes the prerequisite of the others.[126] This indivisible continuity is most

125. Jürgen Moltmann, *Ethics of Hope* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2012), 164.

126. For an exploration of the relation between justice, forgiveness, and peace in the pursuit of the common good, see chapter 4 in the present book.





explicitly articulated in the Old Testament. Reflecting on its radical preoccupation with justice for the other, Levinas remarks,

> The Torah is transcendent and from heaven by its demands that clash, in the final analysis, with the pure ontology of the world. The Torah demands, in opposition to the natural perseverance of each being in his or her own being (a fundamental ontological law), concern for the stranger, the widow and the orphan, a preoccupation with the other person.[127]

The God of the Torah equates righteousness with justice for the poor, the oppressed, the disenfranchised (Deut 10:17–18; 16:19–20). This notion transcends abstraction and culminates in the demand for economic justice through concrete instruction for sharing one's access to life with the fellow human. The text of Deuteronomy 24:17–22 outlines an economic program that cultivates covenantal communal consciousness of responsibility for the other's well-being and commitment to distributive justice for the poor (summed up in the famous triad of "the alien, orphan, and widow,"[128] thus including the immigrant, the stranger, the ethnically and religiously other) while protecting their dignity.

> You shall not deprive a resident alien or an orphan of justice; you shall not take a widow's garment in pledge. . . . When you reap your harvest in your field and forget a sheaf in the field, you shall not go back to get it; it shall be left for the alien, the orphan, and the widow, so that the Lord your God may bless you in all your undertakings. When you beat your olive trees, do not strip what is left; it shall be for the alien, the orphan, and the widow. When you gather the grapes of

127. Emmanuel Levinas, *In the Time of the Nations*, trans. Michael B. Smith (London: Athlone, 1994), 61.

128. For an overview of the meaning and significance of this triad in the Old Testament, see Mark Sneed, "Israelite Concern for the Alien, Orphan, and Widow: Altruism or Ideology?" *Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft* 111, no. 4 (1999): 498–507. The author notes that the triad designates not simply the poor but those who are especially vulnerable in their poverty for they had no kin "to buttress them" and, therefore, had "to take their seats among the blind and lame who begged at the city gates." Sneed states that due to the "lack of kin network to support them" as well as the absence of "any kind of modern welfare system, these social categories were quite vulnerable to oppression (legal and illegal) and annihilation in ancient times" (500–501).

> your vineyard, do not glean what is left; it shall be for the alien, the orphan, and the widow. Remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt; therefore I am commanding you to do this.

Indeed, the protection of human dignity is a fundamental concern of both the Mosaic law and the rabbinic tradition. An uninvited (not intentionally embraced as in ascetic practices) poverty humiliates and subjugates the person to degrading conditions of existence that could be partially alleviated by others' charity. While charity (in its conventional forms of monetary-giving or providing food, clothing, and shelter) temporarily breaks the cycle of suffering and want, it rarely offers long-term solutions. While it dignifies the giver, it may create a sense of helpless dependence in the recipient. While humanitarian relief is essential for economic interventions (and, as already observed, is a fundamental Christian mandate, Matt 25), the best form of charity to a healthy adult remains economic empowerment (inseparable from sociopolitical emancipation and demarginalization) through proper employment[129] and related infrastructural prerequisites, such as quality education and professional training, that permanently alleviate hunger and poverty and secure just financial compensation for one's labor.[130] Thus, the instructions of Deuteronomy 24:17–22 protect the dignity of the other by joining benevolence to their labor; all this takes place within the theological understanding that the only true owner of the land, and its fruit, as well as of one's life and personal possessions is God himself, and all in Israel stand equal before him (Lev 25:23–55). The Old Testament highlights charity as God's distributive justice, enacted on behalf of the needy via responsible human agency. The "ways of the Lord" are depicted as righteousness (*tsedaqah*, understood in terms of distributive justice) and justice (*mishpat*, associated also with retributive justice) (Gen 18:17–19), and humanity has to learn them in order to be transformed into his likeness. Thus, the psalmist writes, "I shall behold your face in righteousness; when I awake I will be satisfied, beholding your likeness" (Ps 17:15). Jonathan Sacks points out that the rabbinical tradition translated this verse as "I shall behold Your face through charity, and when I awake, shall be satisfied with Your likeness,"

129. Sacks, *To Heal a Fractured World*, 38.

130. Due to its limitations, the present paper cannot adequately engage the important issue of just pay; however, it could be anticipated that a just society would strive to establish/legislate a minimum wage that is at least equal to (and hopefully even higher than) the properly calculated living wage.





or "I, through charity shall behold Your face."[131] According to Sacks, this is not an unusual translation. *Tsedaqah* is virtually untranslatable because it joins two seemingly mutually exclusive notions—charity and justice, thus articulating a concept of charity as justice.[132] Since not the individual person but God is the owner of everything that exists, then charity is distributive justice. Therefore, (in light of Ps 17:15) charity is a transformative/transfiguring religious experience; it is enactment of the character and nature of God in the world; it is partaking in the divine nature that translates us into the divine presence face to face with our Creator—a redemptive, restorative interface as recollection of Eden in beholding the very countenance of God.

Uplifting the moral character of God, Scripture insists that he loves righteousness (*tsedaqah*—charity as distributive justice) and justice (*mishpat*—retributive justice) (Ps 33:5; 37:28). They are the foundation of his throne (his rule and authority in the universe) (Ps 89:14; 97:2) and "lovingkindness [*hesed*] and truth go before" him (Ps 89:14). When embodied by humanity, *mishpat* and *tsedaqah* become the pathway to redemption (Isa 1:27), and God seeks to cultivate them within his people. Thus, Isaiah 5:7 depicts Israel as the Lord's vineyard in which he looks for righteousness/charity and justice as the fruit of his likeness, but disappointed he finds only "bloodshed" and "a cry of distress." Israel is not fulfilling its destiny to image the Lord in the cosmos; instead they practice oppression and violence against the other (a concern that blazes in the heart of prophetic critique—Jer 22:13; Ezek 22:29; Amos 6:12). They have "committed robbery, and they have wronged the poor and needy and have oppressed the sojourner without justice"; the Lord has "searched for a man among them who should build up the wall and stand in the gap" before him for the land, that it may not be destroyed, but he has found no one (Ezek 22:29–30). No doubt, the hearer of these words is reminded of Abraham's intercession on behalf of Sodom and Gomorrah, a striking conversation with God that reasserts God's righteousness and justice in the midst of a dehumanized and violent world (Gen 18:17–33).[133] Yet

131. Sacks, *To Heal a Fractured World*, 41. There the author quotes the Babylonian Talmud, Baba Batra 10a.

132. Sacks, *To Heal a Fractured World*, 32. As Sacks observes, in the Western mind the two notions usually don't intersect. If a person gives money to another, the recipient is either entitled to it or not. In the first case, the act of giving the money is justice, in the second, charity.

133. Inspired by the concept of embodied righteousness as a bridge of intercession on behalf of the world, the Jewish mystical tradition speaks of *Lamed-Vav Tzadikim* (or *lamed-vovniks*)—thiry-six righteous people because of whom the world continues to exist and is not destroyed. The most important characteristic that they all share is that they themselves don't

God's promise is to renew and heal his people and all the earth by joining (betrothing) them to himself in righteousness and justice, in lovingkindness and compassion (Hos 2:19). They will be one with their maker in theosis for his law will be internalized in them; it will be written on their hearts; it will become their new nature in God (Jer 31:33) and their actions will translate their ontological renewal into the world, bringing it into accordance with the very Word that has made it.

Indeed, Deuteronomy 24:17–22 is a remarkable text that together with such passages as Deuteronomy 15:7–11, as well as the entire scriptural segment dealing with the institution of the Jubilee (the return of ancestral lands to their original owners and a "year of release" of the slaves), charts (as established by the Torah) what could be seen as "an early form of welfare state."[134] Yet, as Rabbi Sacks observes, the uniqueness of this socioeconomic construct is that it did not depend on the state and was not sustained by its power, but "by moral responsibility and the network of obligations created by the covenant at Sinai."[135] The law, as pedagogy of moral formation in the life of Israel, was to shape and form the people of God as a society of equals and assure equal dignity for all. Thus, Henry George remarks,

> the great concern of Moses was with the duty that lay plainly before him; the effort to lay the foundation of a social state in which deep poverty and degrading want should be unknown—where men released from the meaner struggles that waste human energy should have opportunity for intellectual and moral development.[136]

know that they are counted in that number. This Jewish belief is based on a talmudic assertion that in each generation there are thirty-six righteous individuals who "greet the Shekhinah," the very presence of God (Sanhedrin 97b; Sukkah 45b). In relation to the hospitality that Abraham offered to God which preceded his intercession for the two cities and which the rabbis spoke of as meeting/greeting the *Shekhinah*, see the commentary on the related talmudic passages by Nancy Flam in "'Pass Not Away': Yearning for a Seamless Life of Connection," in *Jewish Mysticism and the Spiritual Life: Classical Texts, Contemporary Reflections*, ed. Lawrence Fine, Eitan Fishbane, and Or N. Rose (Woodstock, VT: Jewish Light, 2010), 3–14.

134. Sacks, *To Heal a Fractured World*, 34.

135. Sacks, *To Heal a Fractured World*, 34. As Sacks states, "The message of the Hebrew Bible is that civilizations survive not by strength but by how they care for the poor; not by power but by their concern for the powerless. What renders a culture invulnerable is the compassion it shows to the vulnerable" (37).

136. Henry George, *Moses: A Lecture*. This famous text was delivered originally as a lecture in 1878 in San Francisco and in 1884 in Dundee, Scotland. Consequently, the text was published multiple times by various publishers. (It can be found as a free source at http://www





Indeed, in both Jewish thought and early Christianity the notions of equality and justice are inseparable. Thus, in the words of Philo of Alexandria, equality is "the mother of justice" and justice is the "offspring" of equality.[137] No doubt, the theme of equality as the foundation for justice continued to preoccupy Jewish thought during the time of Jesus and the apostles and was translated into the early Christian ethos as evidenced by such noncanonical Jewish-Christian texts as the Sibylline Oracles.[138] The oracles forecast a stunning eschatological vision of equality and social justice:

> And equal land for all, divided not by walls or fences; more abundant fruits spontaneous shall then bear, and the course of life be common and wealth unapportioned. For there no longer will be poor nor rich, tyrant nor slave, nor any great nor small, nor kings nor leaders; all alike in common.[139]

As equality births justice, so justice bears peace. Thus, the oracles culminate in the proclamation of a transfigured world marked by the cessation of violence that encompasses the healing of all the earth as humanity's home:

> Nor sword nor uproar shall be on the earth; no more shall earth groan heavily and quake; nor shall war longer be on earth, nor drought, nor

.cooperativeindividualism.org/george-henry_moses-a-lecture-1878.html) The author asserts: "It is not the protection of property, but the protection of humanity, that is the aim of the Mosaic code. Its sanctions are not directed to securing the strong in heaping up wealth so much as to preventing the weak from being crowded to the wall. At every point it interposes its barriers to the selfish greed that, if left unchecked, will surely differentiate men into landlord and serf, capitalist and workman, millionaire and tramp, ruler and ruled. Its Sabbath day and Sabbath year secure, even to the lowliest, rest and leisure. With the blast of the jubilee trumpets the slave goes free, the debt that cannot be paid is canceled, and a re-division of the land secures again to the poorest his fair share in the bounty of the common Creator. The reaper must leave something for the gleaner; even the ox cannot be muzzled as he treadeth out the corn. Everywhere, in everything, the dominant idea is that of our homely phrase—'Live and let live!'"

137. For Philo, "the principle of equality" is the most important (praiseworthy) part of justice: "equality is a light which is never shaded" (*The Works of Philo Judaeus, Special Laws* 4, 42 [230]). (http://www.earlychristianwritings.com/yonge/book30.html)

138. For an inspiring theological engagement of the Sibylline Oracles, see Crossan, *God and Empire*, 78–82.

139. *The Sibylline Oracles*, book 2, 390–96, trans. Milton S. Terry (New York: Eaton and Mains, 1899), 20.

> famine, nor the fruit-destroying hail; but great peace shall be upon all the earth, and king to king be friend until the end of the age.[140]

These visions of social transformation affirm the indivisibility of political, economic, and ecological justice, and forecast the necessity of all three for the establishment of peace as access to life and healing of the cosmos. Lack of political justice breeds the conditions for economic exploitation and inequality. The same greed and self-indulgence that commodify the other and justify their savage exploitation underwrite the devastating exploitation of nature. As Moltmann remarks:

> There is a negative correlation between the social condition of human beings and their relationship to nature: if the exploitation of the work force is dominant in the social structures, then the relationship to nature will also be determined by exploitation of the earth's mineral resources. The exploitative relationship of the human being to nature will stop only if the exploitative relationship of people to one another stops too. Ecological justice will only be acquired at the same time as economic justice.[141]

In the wise and righteous structure of the universe are visible "the checks and balances" of divinely established limitations/boundaries that are not to be transgressed. Thus, ecological limits are placed on economic growth,[142] which in turn make terminal to both society and nature the unrestrained exploitation of one human being by another. Therefore, the law is given as the words of comprehensive justice (a verbalized expression of God's righteousness and providential care for creation) that articulate these limitations and bring the warning that the choice between their fulfillment or transgression makes all the difference between life and death, between a blessing and a curse (Deut 11:26), not only for the individual, but for his or her community and the rest of the world.

The divinely imposed guards/restrictions against economic and ecological injustice and social inequality built within the structures of the cosmos are made explicit within the (mandated by the law) liturgical life of Israel—a perpetual, living memorial of the original act of creation and its onto-

140. *The Sibylline Oracles*, book 3, 935–39.
141. Moltmann, *Ethics of Hope*, 221.
142. Moltmann, *Ethics of Hope*, 221.





logical renewal through redeemed human communal agency. The human communal covenant grafted within the covenantal communion with God uplifts the radically equalizing demands of the Sabbath (and the Sabbath year) extending rest to both the anthropic and nonanthropic creation as well as the elaborate instructions of the Jubilee along with the commands concerning giving every third year a tithe to charity for the needy, including the noncovenantal strangers and foreigners dwelling among the people of God. Therefore, nonidolatrous worship is manifested in the immediate communal effects of equality and justice as access to life for all of God's creatures.

It is not accidental that the New Testament summation of the law and the prophets is articulated in Jesus's teaching as love for God and neighbor. Love for God as the ultimate other is expressed in love for the immediate other and manifested as intentional, proactive care for their flourishing. Therefore, the love of God is experienced by the fellow human as a distributive justice. As John Dominic Crossan proposes, "justice and love are a dialectic" in which: "Justice is the body of love, love is the soul of justice. Justice is the flesh of love, love is the spirit of justice. When they are separated, we have a moral corpse. Justice without love is brutality. Love without justice is banality."[143]

Since distributive justice is inscribed in the very ontology of creation and is indispensable from its all-summoning destiny in union with its just Creator (accomplished through the socio-transformative pedagogy of communal, liturgical life), both the Old and New Testaments take a passionate stand against any attempt to use worship in order to avoid doing justice to the fellow human. Thus, the prophetic critique of Hosea 6:6 insists that God desires steadfast love and not sacrifice, "the knowledge of God rather than burnt offerings." This knowledge, evidenced as the living embodiment of the divine Word, prioritizes (in the words of Walter Brueggemann) "covenantal solidarity over cultic activity"; it seeks the well-being of one's neighbor as the fundamental form of worship in response to the recognition of the divine omnipresence in the world. Acts of distributive justice consecrate the human community and the rest of creation as a sacred space for encounter and communion with God; they unveil a renewed vision of the cosmos as a temple and of distributive justice as a sacramental practice that humanizes the human community, displaying (making once again visible) the divine image within the cosmic sanctuary. Undoubtedly, some of the strongest negations of the utilization of worship as a substitute for justice are found in

143. Crossan, *God and Empire*, 190.

the words of Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Amos. The famous text in Isaiah 1:14–17 shakes the reader with its uncompromising refusal to accommodate injustice under the cover of religious devotion:

> Your new moons and your appointed festivals my soul hates; they have become a burden to me, I am weary of bearing them. When you stretch out your hands, I will hide my eyes from you; even though you make many prayers, I will not listen; your hands are full of blood. Wash yourselves; make yourselves clean; remove the evil of your doings from before my eyes; cease to do evil, learn to do good; seek justice, rescue the oppressed, defend the orphan, plead for the widow.

The denial of justice to the needy is depicted as bloodshed, an act of premeditated violence against them. The blood of the fellow human cries out to God from the palms of the very hands lifted for worship in his presence, demanding divine intervention. Eventually, retribution comes as banishment from the land, for exile becomes the only way of cleansing it from the evil nested in its people. Thus, Jeremiah 6:20 reechoes the assertion that cultic activity will not compensate for the injustice done by Israel ("Your burnt-offerings are not acceptable, nor are your sacrifices pleasing to me") and proclaims the only conditions under which the divine verdict would be altered, for instead of burnt offerings, the Lord "delights" in "steadfast love (*hesed*), justice (*mishpat*) and righteousness (*tsedaqah*)"—the very marks of his own activity on earth (Jer 9:24) that the ones called by his name should also enact as the way of their worship-embodied life.[144] Therefore, Yahweh states,

> Amend your ways and your doings, and let me dwell with you in this place. Do not trust in these deceptive words: "This is the temple of the Lord, the temple of the Lord, the temple of the Lord." For if you truly amend your ways and your doings, if you truly act justly one with another, if you do not oppress the alien, the orphan, and the widow, or shed innocent blood in this place, and if you do not go after other gods to your own hurt, then I will dwell with you in this place, in the land that I gave of old to your ancestors for ever and ever. (Jer 7:3–7)

144. For a more in-depth reflection on Jer 9:24, see Brueggemann, *Journey to the Common Good*, 62–63.





Perhaps the strongest protest against concealed-in-worship injustice is found in Amos 5:21–24 (paraphrasing the divine discontent expressed in Isa 1:14–17):

> I hate, I despise your festivals, and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies. Even though you offer me your burnt-offerings and grain-offerings, I will not accept them; and the offerings of well-being of your fatted animals I will not look upon. Take away from me the noise of your songs; I will not listen to the melody of your harps. But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream.

Using cultic activity as a compensation for the lack of justice is a perversion of the very essence of creation in which the glory of the Creator is (in Sallie McFague's beautiful paraphrase of Saint Irenaeus) "every creature fully alive."[145] Therefore, worship without justice is idolatry: it serves other gods (among which are greed, egoism, and self-indulgence), sacrificing before them the very life and well-being of the fellow human and the rest of creation. The gospels join the warning against such idolatrous distortion of God's world (and thus, of the very Word inscribed in its fibers and articulated in the law as the way to life) by asserting the impossibility of serving both God and "Mammon" (Matt 6:24; Luke 16:13). Matthew 15:5–9 and Mark 7:10–13 condemn worship without distributive justice as "invalidating" God's Word by the practice of religious traditions. The teaching of Christ, the embodied Word, recollects in these gospel passages the words of Isaiah 29:13: "these people draw near with their mouths and honor me with their lips, while their hearts are far from me, and their worship of me is a human commandment learned by rote."

The Synoptic Gospels' protest against the religious justification of injustice culminates in the so-called "cleansing of the temple" scene (recorded in Matt 21:12–16; Mark 11:15–17; Luke 19:45–46). This is a depiction of the Son of Man's prophetic act of reconsecrating "the house" of the Creator and its cultic function as a sanctuary for God's entire household (that includes "all the nations," Mark 11:17) and with it symbolically purifying all of creation (the cosmic temple) for its sacramental purpose—the indwelling of and communion with the divine presence. This radical gesture could be understood

145. Sallie McFague, *Life Abundant: Rethinking Theology and Economy for a Planet in Peril* (Minneapolis: Augsburg Fortress, 2001), 3.

as a symbolic summary and enactment of the first parousia's mission. Both the divinely constructed temple (cosmic creation)[146] and its human-made replica are to be places of safety, healing, and generous hospitality to God's creatures, but instead they have been usurped and permeated with systemic violence against the other through the practice of economic injustice. The use of religious authority to justify extortion and racketeering has reduced the temple to a "robbers' den." In light of this, John Dominic Crossan sees in this scene "a symbolic destruction of the Temple" based on the prophecy of Jeremiah 7:14: "I will do to the house which is called by My name, in which you trust, and to the place which I gave you and your fathers, as I did to Shiloh."[147]

This striking, deliberate act of the incarnate Word (previously spoken through the prophets) finds its conclusion in the healing of all "the blind and the lame" who come to him in the temple (Matt 21:14), thus embodying the restored purpose of the sacred structure as the location from where the healing of the entire cosmos is initiated. Indeed, as N. T. Wright observes, in this intense scene, Jesus reveals himself as the "one-man-temple-alternative"[148]—in him God has accomplished the telos of humanity (its renewed ontology) as a divinely constructed, living temple for his presence. There the poor and the needy find access to life more abundant.

No wonder the scene appears as a prelude to the passion of Christ. There is no other way to put an end to the world's violent brutalization except by absorbing it into himself and refusing to retaliate as his tortured, broken body engulfs all victimization of the other and his death swallows death and the grave. As all of his life, Christ's passion is a fulfillment of the Word and an authenticating illustration through embodiment of his teaching. (Indeed, in his life and death, the incarnate Word interprets and fulfills the proclaimed and written Word.)[149] Thus, the passion becomes an enactment of the last two of the six great precepts recorded in Matthew 5:38–45 and considered the foremost distinction of Christian ethics:

146. For more on creation as the first God-made sanctuary/temple and the temple in Jerusalem as its replica, see chapter 3 of this book.

147. Crossan, *God and Empire*, 133.

148. N. T. Wright, "Jesus' Self-Understanding," in *The Incarnation*, ed. Stephen T. Davis, Daniel Kendall, S.J., and Gerald O'Collins, S.J. (New York: Oxford University Press, 2002), 47–61, there 57.

149. Indeed, as Anthony Godzieba points out, "the embodied enactment of the values" of God's kingdom "is critical to their claim to truth." "'Stay with us . . .' (Luke 24:29)—'Come, Lord Jesus' (Rev. 22:20): Incarnation, Eschatology, and Theology's Sweet Predicament," *Theological Studies* 67 (2006): 783–95 (791).





> You have heard that it was said, "An eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth." But I say to you, Do not resist an evildoer. But if anyone strikes you on the right cheek, turn the other also. . . . Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, so that you may be children of your Father in heaven; for he makes his sun rise on the evil and on the good, and sends rain on the righteous and on the unrighteous.

The paschal suffering of the Messiah is a decisive refusal to perpetuate the cycle of violence induced by humanity's sin in the world: refusal that culminates in forgiveness to the perpetrators (which, in the transepochal reality of Christ's crucifixion, extends beyond "Jewish religious cooperation with Roman imperial control"[150] to encompass all humanity). Thus, in its mystical essence of all-engulfing cosmic redemption, Christ's violent death on the cross marks the ultimate end of violence against the other and the beginning of peace as reconciliation with God and neighbor. The cross's salvific power points to the paradox of peace building, in which the victim is "the one who has the key to a real and fundamental reconciliation, because it is in the victim that Jesus Christ is present."[151] Thus, each act of forgiveness drives the cosmos to its eschatological telos of summoning in the cosmic Christ. If creation comes forth as means of communion with God and a Christoforming pedagogy, then forgiveness is anticipated by and "written into the structure of the universe."[152] As Teilhard de Chardin's breathtaking prose reminds us,

> One day, the Gospel tells us, the tension gradually accumulated between humanity and God will touch the limits prescribed by the possibilities of the world. And then will come the end. The presence of Christ, which has been silently accruing in things, will suddenly be revealed—like a flash of light from pole to pole. Breaking through all

150. Crossan, *God and Empire*, 132.

151. Emilio Castro, "Reconciliation," in *The Ecumenical Movement: An Anthology of Key Texts and Voices*, ed. Michael Kinnamon and Brian E. Cope (Geneva: World Council of Churches, 1997), 67.

152. Sacks, *To Heal a Fractured World*, 25. Reflecting on the pedagogical function of creation, Sacks points out that in the process of learning "we will stumble and fall, but only by so doing does a child learn to walk. . . . God asks us only to acknowledge our mistakes and to learn from them." Therefore, forgiveness is anticipated by and inscribed within the reality of creation's pedagogy.

> the barriers within which the veil of matter and the water-tightness souls have seemingly kept it confined, it will invade the face of the earth.[153]

Until that day when Christ will shine forth through the opacity of his creation, becoming visible to all, his indwelling presence is unveiled in courageous love for God and neighbor amidst a violence-plagued world: a love that forgives, refuses to hate or to become the enemy, cherishes the other with their hopes for the future, and fills the space between oneself and the fellow human with healing acts of lovingkindness.

153. Pierre Teilhard de Chardin, *The Divine Milieu* (New York: HarperCollins, 2001), 129–30.



*Chapter 3*

# Recovering of Eucharistic Being in a Market-Shaped World

The world is a market! Hardly anyone would contradict this statement today. The process of globalization, as the technologically induced compression of time and space, has lent a true sense of omnipresence to Western neoliberal capitalism and its all-commodifying market logic. Global economic integration has insured that the entire world may share the devastating impact of each crisis engineered in the prosperous stock markets of the West by unholy trading and lending practices. Thus, in 2008 the global economy absorbed and "equitably" distributed the negative outcome of Wall Street's moral irresponsibility, making everyone pay for the greedy appetites of a few. It could be argued that every person in the world was/is subjugated in one way or another to the effects of this economic crisis (e.g., through the loss of "investments, retirement, college savings; a home lost to foreclosure or a job lost to cutbacks; or simply the increased debt burden"[1] of national governments as well as through the reduction of charitable giving toward international and domestic projects).[2]

Yet we are told that moral values are irrelevant to the market—that markets are morally neutral and navigated by scientifically assessable economic

1. Rebecca Todd Peters, "Examining the Economic Crisis as a Crisis of Values," *Interpretation* (April 2011): 154–66 (154).

2. In their 2012 book *Declaration*, Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri argue that "neoliberalism and its crisis have shifted the terms of economic and political life, but they have also operated a social, anthropological transformation, fabricating new figures of subjectivity. For example, the "hegemony of finance and the banks has produced *the indebted*" (9). As the authors state, being in debt "is becoming the general condition of social life" today (10). In a way, "*debtfare*" has become the substitute to *welfare*. Hardt and Negri assert that exploitation's primary manifestation today is not unequal exchange but debt, transforming the creditor-indebted relationship into a new master-slave mode of existence in which the poverty of the enslaved "is characterized primarily by the chains of debt" (13) (*Declaration* [Argo Navis Author Services, 2012]).